ship qualities, he lacks an organisation.

The trouble with Rahul Gandhi is just the reverse: compared to AAP, the Congress has a pan-national organisation, but he has so far not demonstrated any ability to knit together and lead a disparate coalition. He also can't counter the criticism against him, especially over his many unexplained jaunts abroad, suggesting that politics for him is more a hobby rather than the lifetime commitment it is for Modi. Nor has the Congress been able to come down hard on the government on economic issues. During the just-concluded Parliament session, they tried to organise a national protest on inflation and unemployment, but the timing was off as both Rahul and Sonia Gandhi were being interrogated by the Enforcement Directorate on alleged financial irregularities in *National Herald* ownership.

Other Opposition leaders have their own sets of limitations. While Mamata proved to be a formidable opponent to Modi and the BJP in West Bengal, inflicting a crushing defeat on them in the 2021 assembly polls, her subsequent efforts to project herself as a national alternative to Modi did not bear much fruit. Nitish's ditching of the BJP and return to the *mahagathbandhan* fold in Bihar have made him a serious Opposition contender to Modi. But his frequent political U-turns have dented his political credibility. For the moment, then, the TINA (There is No Alternative) factor remains heavily in Modi's favour.

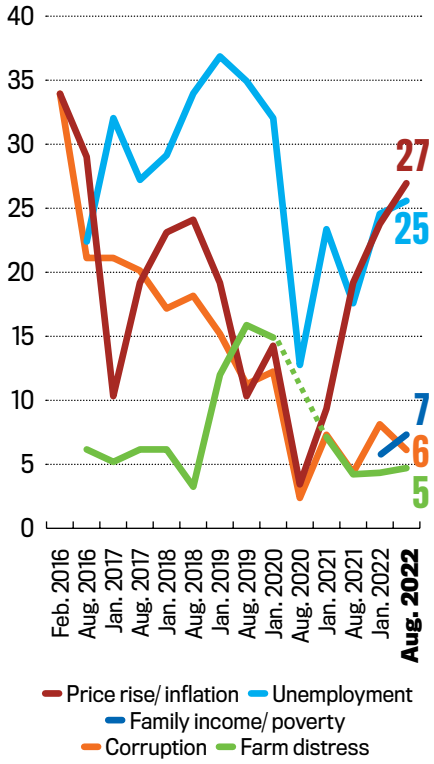
The other major reason for Modi retaining his popularity is the clever mix he has followed of delivering on the Hindutva agenda by paving the way for the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya and abrogating Article 370 in Kashmir while appropriating the socialist plank by executing an extensive welfare agenda. The implosion of Left parties across the country save in Kerala has enabled the BJP to thrive. There is thus no credible Bernie Sanders kind of figure in the Opposition to ask Modi what he has done to provide jobs, control prices, improve health and reduce poverty, or to cash in on the perception this MOTN throws up—of his government's economic initiatives favouring big business.

Modi has also managed to play the hypernationalist card effectively, especially in India's dealings with Pakistan and China, which has won him support among MOTN respondents. He is seen as a tough leader who, while upholding India's best interests internationally, is putting an energetic shoulder to the wheel in sorting out the country's economic woes. However, the MOTN poll flags some worrying trends: including a significant number who believe that Indian democracy is in danger and that communal tension is on the rise. They should serve as warning signals to the Modi government that all is not well.

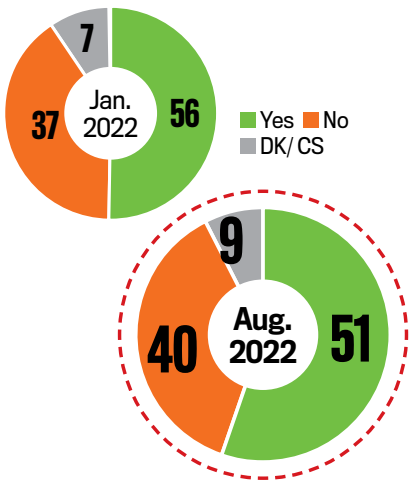
Once seen as a party with a difference, the BJP is in danger of losing that sheen in its quest for power at any cost. The party has successfully destabilised opposition governments in Madhya Pradesh, Goa and, more recently, in Maharashtra by engineering defections, but it has not got done down well with everyone. The Modi government is also being accused of unleashing central agencies such as the Enforcement Directorate and the Central Bureau of Investigation to browbeat its opponents into silence. A number of MOTN respondents back the BJP's tactics of poaching MLAs and don't blame it for misusing investigative agencies. But the party cannot take much comfort in the fact as the gap between its approvers and disapprovers has narrowed significantly. Despite its shenanigans, you can now drive from Kanyakumari to Kathmandu via Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Jharkhand and now Bihar without crossing a BJP state. So, even with all its strengths, the party remains vulnerable.

The other imperative for Modi is to develop a strong second line of leadership that could champion the initiatives his government has undertaken

Q. What is the biggest problem India currently faces?



Q. Has the Modi government been able to reduce corruption in India?



All figures in percentage